

Sleep, Stress and Mental Health

The hidden health crisis: why rest and stress management matter as much as diet and exercise

sleep deprivation · cortisol · melatonin · mental health · anxiety · depression · chronic stress · resilience · sleep cycle · deep sleep · cognitive function · fatigue · insomnia · mindfulness · blood pressure · burnout · sleep hygiene · hormones · self-care · wellbeing

Most people understand that eating well and exercising regularly are important for good health. But there is a third pillar of healthy living that is often overlooked — and it may be just as important as the other two. Sleep and stress management are not luxuries. They are biological necessities. Without adequate sleep, even the best diet and exercise routine will fail to deliver their full benefits. And without effective ways to manage **chronic stress**, the body gradually breaks down — physically, mentally, and emotionally.

In today's fast-paced world, **sleep deprivation** and **chronic stress** have become dangerously normalised. Many people wear their tiredness like a badge of honour, believing that sleeping less and working more is a sign of ambition and strength. The science tells a very different story. Before we look at what the research shows, consider these two situations:

1 You have an important deadline tomorrow. It is midnight and you are not finished. What do you do?

a I stay up until 2 or 3am to finish — the work is more important than sleep tonight.

b I stop at a reasonable time, sleep for 7–8 hours, and finish with a fresh mind in the morning.

2 You have been feeling overwhelmed and anxious for several weeks. What do you do?

a I push through and hope the feeling goes away — I am too busy to deal with it right now.

b I recognise it as a sign that something needs to change and I take steps to manage my stress.

If you chose b) both times, you are already thinking like someone who understands the science of recovery. Research consistently shows that sleep-deprived people make more mistakes, think less clearly, and are far more vulnerable to **anxiety** and **depression**. And people who ignore **chronic stress** for long periods of time are at significantly higher risk of **burnout**, heart disease, and serious **mental health** problems. This article explains why — and what you can do about it.

PART ONE · THE SCIENCE OF SLEEP

Sleep is not passive. Far from being a period of inactivity, sleep is one of the most biologically active and important parts of your day. While you sleep, your brain processes and stores the information it gathered during the day, consolidating memories and clearing out waste products that build up in brain tissue. Your body repairs damaged cells, produces **hormones** that regulate growth and hunger, and restores the immune

system. Without adequate sleep, none of these processes can happen properly.

The **sleep cycle** lasts approximately 90 minutes and repeats several times each night. It moves through several stages, including light sleep, **deep sleep**, and a phase called REM (Rapid Eye Movement) sleep — the stage in which most dreaming occurs and in which the brain is especially active in processing emotions and memories. Missing out on deep sleep or REM sleep — which happens when you sleep for fewer than 7 hours — has serious consequences for **cognitive function**, mood regulation, and physical health.

"After 17 hours without sleep, your cognitive performance is equivalent to having a blood alcohol level of 0.05%. After 24 hours, it reaches 0.10% — above the legal driving limit in most countries." — Sleep Research Society

Sleep deprivation — getting significantly less sleep than your body needs — has effects that go far beyond simply feeling tired. Even a single night of poor sleep raises **cortisol** levels, the body's primary stress hormone, making you more anxious, more emotionally reactive, and less able to control your responses to difficult situations. Over time, chronic sleep deprivation is linked to obesity, type 2 diabetes, cardiovascular disease, weakened immunity, and significantly increased risk of **anxiety** and **depression**. The hormone **melatonin**, produced by the brain in darkness, plays a central role in regulating the **sleep cycle** — and exposure to bright screens before bed suppresses its production, making it harder to fall asleep.

1 in 3

adults regularly get less sleep than they need

40%

higher risk of obesity with fewer than 6 hrs sleep

17 hrs

without sleep = impaired as a drunk driver

7–9 hrs

sleep needed nightly for most healthy adults

■ GOOD SLEEP HYGIENE

- Keep a consistent sleep schedule — go to bed and wake up at the same time every day.
- Avoid screens (phones, tablets, laptops) for at least one hour before bed.
- Keep your bedroom cool, dark, and quiet — your environment matters.
- Avoid caffeine after 2pm, as it stays in your system for up to 8 hours.
- Exercise regularly — but not within 2–3 hours of bedtime.

■ HABITS THAT HARM SLEEP

- Irregular sleep times — staying up late on weekends disrupts your **sleep cycle**.
- Scrolling through your phone in bed — blue light suppresses **melatonin** production.
- Drinking alcohol to help you sleep — it reduces **deep sleep** and REM sleep.
- Eating a large meal late at night — digestion interferes with sleep quality.
- Napping for more than 20–30 minutes during the day — it makes night sleep harder.

Not all stress is bad. Short-term stress — the kind you feel before an exam, a job interview, or an important presentation — is a normal and healthy biological response. It sharpens your focus, increases your energy, and prepares your body to perform under pressure. This is sometimes called the 'fight or flight' response, and it evolved to help our ancestors respond to immediate physical danger. Once the stressful situation is over, the body returns to its normal state.

The problem arises when stress becomes chronic — when it is constant, ongoing, and never fully resolved. Chronic stress keeps cortisol levels permanently elevated, which has deeply damaging effects on the body over time. High cortisol suppresses the immune system, raises blood pressure, disrupts sleep, increases appetite for high-calorie food, and interferes with the production of hormones that regulate mood and wellbeing. Over time, chronic stress significantly increases the risk of anxiety, depression, heart disease, and burnout — a state of complete physical and emotional exhaustion from which recovery can take months or years.

The relationship between stress, sleep, and mental health is circular and self-reinforcing. Stress makes it harder to sleep. Poor sleep raises cortisol and makes stress harder to manage. Higher stress and worse sleep both increase the risk of anxiety and depression. And anxiety and depression make both sleep and stress management even harder. Breaking this cycle requires deliberate, consistent effort — but the good news is that it is entirely possible.

PART THREE · MENTAL HEALTH AND RESILIENCE

Mental health is not simply the absence of illness. It is an active state of wellbeing in which a person is able to cope with the normal stresses of life, work productively, and contribute to their community. Good mental health requires the same kind of consistent daily investment as good physical health — it does not maintain itself automatically.

One of the most important concepts in mental health research is resilience — the ability to recover from setbacks, adapt to difficult circumstances, and keep moving forward. Resilience is not something you either have or do not have. It is a skill that can be built and strengthened over time, through practices such as mindfulness, regular exercise, strong social connections, and learning to identify and challenge unhelpful patterns of thinking. People with high resilience do not experience fewer difficult events — they simply recover from them more quickly and effectively.

One of the most well-researched approaches to building mental resilience is mindfulness — the practice of deliberately paying attention to the present moment, without judgement. Studies show that regular mindfulness practice reduces anxiety, lowers cortisol levels, improves sleep, and strengthens cognitive function. It does not require special equipment or a lot of time — even ten minutes of focused breathing per day has been shown to produce measurable benefits. Combined with regular physical activity, good sleep hygiene, and strong social support, it forms the foundation of genuine long-term wellbeing.

PRACTICAL TIPS · SIX THINGS YOU CAN START TODAY

■ Fix your sleep schedule

Go to bed and wake up at the same time every day — even on weekends. Consistency is the single most effective sleep improvement you can make.

■ No screens before bed

Blue light from phones and laptops suppresses **melatonin**. Put your screen down at least one hour before you want to sleep.

■ Try mindfulness

Just 10 minutes of focused breathing per day reduces **anxiety** and lowers **cortisol**. Apps like Headspace or Calm can help you start.

■ Exercise for your mind

Physical activity is one of the most powerful treatments for **anxiety** and **depression**. Even a 20-minute walk has an immediate effect on mood.

■ Connect with others

Social connection is one of the strongest predictors of good **mental health**. Make time for people who support you — it is not a luxury.

🏠 ■ Write it down

Journalling — writing about your thoughts and feelings — reduces the mental load of **chronic stress** and helps you identify unhelpful patterns.

The most important thing to understand about sleep, stress, and **mental health** is that they are not separate from physical health — they are inseparable from it. Every hour of good sleep, every moment of genuine rest, and every strategy you develop for managing stress makes your diet work better, your exercise more effective, and your immune system stronger. **Self-care** is not selfishness. It is the foundation on which everything else is built.

■ TALKING POINTS

Do you think sleep deprivation is taken seriously enough in modern culture? Why do some people see sleeping less as a sign of hard work?

The article describes a 'cycle' of stress, poor sleep, and mental health problems. Have you ever experienced this? How did you break it?

What do you think is the biggest barrier to good mental health in your country — stigma, lack of support, lifestyle, or something else?

Would you consider trying mindfulness or journalling? What do you think would be the hardest part of making it a daily habit?